

The Bay a Shogunate Could Not Defend: Yokosuka's Iron Works and Naval Port

A scattering of fishing hamlets on a drowned, hilly coast became the shogunate's last great construction project, built to the design of a French engineer by the finance minister it later executed as a rebel. Reclaimed ground, a naval district, an earthquake and an occupying navy have kept remaking the shoreline ever since; the US Navy holds much of it still.



横須賀（神奈川県横須賀市）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1700 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A scattered hamlet on a drowned coast

Yokosuka's harbor is a drowned valley, and the Geospatial Information Authority's landform survey still reads the ground around it as mostly former water, slope and reclaimed fill rather than solid natural terrace. Before the shipyard that made the city's name, a 1917 study of the district describes only a scattering of fishing hamlets here: twelve households on the western shore of Katsuriki Point, and some ninety-six in total across the inlet's edge, with travelers between Uraga and Edo crossing by ferry near the old Suwa Shrine. Otaki-cho, now the densest commercial street in the city, was then, the same source records, no more than two or three thatched huts at the foot of a hill, reachable on foot along the shore only at low tide.¹⁸

The name Yokosuka is older than that fishing hamlet suggests. A 1936 guide published by the city's chamber of commerce traces the Miura Peninsula's medieval lords back to the Miura clan, who held it for some four and a half centuries from the eleventh century and rose to lead the Kamakura shogunate's own military bureau; by the time the Odawara Hojo dominated the peninsula in the sixteenth century, the guide records, a named local lord, Yokosuka Aki-no-kami Sadatoki, held Yokosuka itself as a fief, with neighboring holdings under other Hojo vassals. Only after Tokugawa Ieyasu took the Kanto region in 1590 and placed the peninsula under a shogunate magistrate did the named fief fade into the scattered, nameless fishing hamlets the 1917 study describes.¹⁰

Perry's ships, and the shipyard that followed

The bay's transformation began offshore. In 1853 American warships entered Uraga Bay, a short distance south of this study area at Kurihama, breaking, in the words of the 1917 study, "the two-hundred-odd-year dream" of the shogunate's closed coast; when the Americans returned that autumn, the shogunate dropped its old ban on building large ships and let individual domains try. Mito's lord had a three-masted Western-style sailing ship built at Uraga; another was built at Ishikawajima in Edo Bay; the shogunate bought two steamers from abroad and the Saga domain a third. None of it added up to a shipbuilding industry, and an 1857 ironworks the shogunate opened at Nagasaki, using ten hired Dutch engineers, proved too remote and too small to build a proper warship.¹

The answer was a purpose-built yard inside Edo Bay, and the man who pushed it through was Oguri Tadamasa, better known by his court title Kozuke-no-suke, at the time the shogunate's finance commissioner. In 1864 he and the inspector Kurimoto Sehei opened talks with the French minister Léon Roches, who recommended a French engineer then working in Shanghai, François Léonce Verny. Oguri's own first idea, a 1934 memorial pamphlet on his career records, was modest: a \$40,000 repair yard using machinery already donated by the Saga domain. Roches's enthusiasm expanded it into a four-year, \$2.4 million project, and construction began with a groundbreaking ceremony on 15 November 1865, to Verny's design — the direct origin, by the arsenal's own later account, of what is now the Yokosuka Naval Arsenal.¹²¹³

The magistrate who built a navy and died a rebel

Oguri did not live to see his shipyard finished. Born in 1827 into a hereditary bannerman family with a 2,500-koku stipend, he had already served on the 1860 mission to Washington that exchanged ratifications of Japan's treaty with the United States, and held the finance commissioner's post three separate times before Yokosuka. When the shogunate's forces were defeated at Toba-Fushimi in January 1868, Oguri argued for continued resistance and was, according to the 1934 pamphlet's account, personally dismissed by the shogun himself — the only instance, it states, of a shogunal retainer being dismissed by direct order of the shogun in the whole of the Tokugawa period. He withdrew to his own fief at Gonda village in Kozuke province, was accused of plotting insurrection by the new imperial army advancing from the north, and was captured and beheaded beside the Karasu River on 27 May 1868, at the age of forty-two. The shipyard he had founded outlived him by more than a century and a half, and now forms the core of a modern naval base.²¹²

Reclaiming a naval city

Around the growing arsenal, the shoreline itself had to be manufactured. The 1917 study traces the sequence in detail: Shioiri was created in 1869 by levelling a hill into a reed-choked wetland; the flat approach to what became Yokosuka Station was built in 1871 by filling part of Hemmi village's coast and cutting down another hill to form Minato-cho; ten formal town names, among them Motomachi and Suwa, were only fixed in May 1875, replacing paddies and forest that until then had no names at all. Private reclamation followed through the late 1870s — a group led by Ogawa Shigechika filled ground east of Inaoka in 1878, and a Kamoi innkeeper named Takahashi Katsushichi reclaimed the shore east of Otaki in 1879 to create Wakamatsu-cho, cutting a new road toward Fukada village. In 1880 the whole of Tomarisato was bought up for the shipyard's own expansion. Yokosuka absorbed Hemmi village in 1889 and reached city status on 15 February 1907. The Imperial Navy formalised the site's strategic role in between: in 1884, the first of what became four Japanese naval districts was raised here, ahead of Kure and Sasebo in 1889 and Maizuru in 1901, and it was under French technical guidance that the yard built Japan's first stone dry dock and a three-ton steam hammer, before Japanese-trained engineers went on to build the country's third dry dock unaided.¹⁴

1923: a city built on fill

Yokosuka sat close enough to the Great Kanto earthquake's Sagami Bay epicenter that the 1932 official record of the disaster calls its shaking exceptionally severe. Much of the city collapsed outright, fires broke out in several quarters, and a huge landslide at the Minato-cho cliff buried the road under what the record describes as tens of thousands of tsubo of earth, killing residents caught beneath it; a rumour that more than 150 schoolgirls on an outing had been crushed there spread for months before debris clearance proved it false. City Hall's own building collapsed, killing or injuring several staff, and for months afterward the city government worked from tents pitched in the grounds of the Naval District headquarters, itself nearly levelled but spared by fire; the Naval District's commander-in-chief was made martial-law commander within three days.³

The 1932 record is unusually direct about why the damage fell where it did: the city sat mostly on reclaimed ground, cut hillside or valley fill rather than natural soil, and it was precisely this soft, loose ground that failed hardest, with coastal revetments collapsing wholesale into the sea and the naval port's own north-facing frontage nearly destroyed. The pattern the 1932 surveyors traced by eye — collapse concentrated on filled and cut ground, comparative safety on the old natural slopes — is the same one the modern land-classification maps of this district still show today.³⁸

1945: one navy replaces another

Surrender did not empty the naval base; it changed its flag. By 1944 the Imperial Navy's own yard here covered 280 acres and employed more than 40,000 workers; film held in the US National Archives, and catalogued by Japan's own National Showa Memorial Museum, shows American Marines coming ashore at "Green Beach" on Yokosuka's southern waterfront on 30 August 1945, the day Vice Admiral Totsuka surrendered the base and days before Japan's own formal national surrender, moving through the city's streets to secure it while disarmament continued at Kurihama into early September. Everything the Imperial Navy had built was confiscated; a 1950 national law allowing former naval-port cities to convert military land to civilian use let Yokosuka rebuild parts of the yard as industry and schools, and the city calls that period its turn toward becoming a "peaceful industrial port city." It never fully demilitarised: the city's own current figures put US bases at three facilities across four sites, about 3.36 million square meters, alongside 37 Japanese Self-Defense Force sites covering a further 2.79 million square meters, together some 6 percent of the city's land. Some base land has gone back to civilian use over the decades, including the Inaoka district in 1982 and the former naval officers' club in 1983, but Fleet Activities Yokosuka, 568 acres and by the Navy's own description its largest overseas naval installation, still supports the only aircraft carrier it keeps permanently forward-deployed, USS George Washington, and about 24,000 military and civilian personnel on grounds that overlap the yard Verna built.^{5 11 14 15}

Reading the ground today

The battleship Mikasa, built in England in 1902 and Admiral Togo Heihachiro's flagship in the Russo-Japanese War, was designated a memorial ship in 1926 and is preserved today, by its own trust's account, as the world's oldest surviving steel battleship; under the occupation a private company leasing the ship stripped its upper-deck structures for an aquarium and a dance hall and sold off its guns and masts, until a 1955 newspaper letter from a British trader who had known the ship's crew helped start a national restoration campaign — funded by donations at home and abroad and by the state, including a contribution from the US Navy itself — that culminated in a rededication ceremony on 27 May 1961; it now sits landlocked in concrete at the head of Mikasa Park, at the harbor's edge. A few streets inland, Dobuita-dori still carries the name of a drainage ditch that once ran down its center: the naval arsenal, the shopping street's own association records, supplied the thick iron plates once used to cover it so people and carts could pass, and the plates gave the street its lasting name even after both ditch and iron were long since removed. ⁶⁷¹⁶

Between the two, the town's oldest bones are easiest to find in what does not sit on fill: the old shrine ground, the natural slopes the 1923 record judged safest, and the line of the original shore now buried under Otaki-cho and Minato-cho. Almost everywhere else — the naval district's grounds, the shipyard itself, the flat approach to the station — is reclaimed or cut ground built in the four decades after Oguri's 1865 groundbreaking, a sequence still visible in the sharp edge where the Miura Peninsula's hills give way to the flat, filled shelf the modern port and base now occupy. Comparing the historical and current aerial photography held elsewhere in this dossier package over that same shelf shows how little the base's own outline has changed since the mid-twentieth century, even as the civilian city around it has been rebuilt and, in a few small districts, handed back. ¹⁸⁹

Timeline

11th-16th centuries	The Miura clan, then Sengoku-era lords including Yokosuka Aki-no-kami Sadatoki, hold the peninsula and Yokosuka itself as named fiefs, fading into scattered fishing hamlets after Tokugawa Ieyasu takes the Kanto region in 1590. ¹¹⁰
1853-1857	Perry's ships enter Uruga Bay, just south of this district, ending the shogunate's closed-coast policy; a first ironworks at Nagasaki proves too small and remote to build real warships. ¹
1864	Finance commissioner Oguri Kozuke-no-suke opens talks with French minister Léon Roches on a new shipyard at Yokosuka. ¹²
15 November 1865	Groundbreaking ceremony for the Yokosuka Ironworks, designed by the French engineer Léonce Verny. ²¹³
27 May 1868	Oguri Kozuke-no-suke, dismissed by the shogun and accused of insurrection by the new imperial army, is beheaded at Gonda, Kozuke province. ²¹²
1869-1880	Shioiri, Minato-cho, Ogawa-cho and Wakamatsu-cho are created by successive land reclamation along the shore. ¹
1884	Yokosuka Naval District is established, the first of Japan's four naval districts. ⁴
15 February 1907	Yokosuka is granted city status. ¹
1 September 1923	The Great Kanto earthquake devastates Yokosuka, with the worst damage on reclaimed and cut ground. ³
1926	The battleship Mikasa is designated a memorial ship. ⁶
30 August 1945	US Marines land at Green Beach, Yokosuka, beginning the American Navy's continuous presence at the base. ⁵
1950	A national law lets Yokosuka convert confiscated naval land to civilian industrial and educational use. ¹¹
1958-1961	A preservation campaign, funded partly by the US Navy, restores the neglected Mikasa; it is rededicated on 27 May 1961. ⁶¹⁶
1982-1985	The Inaoka district, the former naval officers' club and Nagai housing are returned from US base land to civilian use. ¹¹

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Verny Park and the former Ironworks waterfront ヴェルニー公園. Faces the US Navy base across the water, close to where Léonce Verny's Yokosuka Ironworks broke ground in 1865; named for the engineer himself.²
- 2

Former Yokosuka Naval District grounds 旧横須賀鎮守府. Site of the naval district established in 1884, nearly destroyed in the 1923 earthquake but pressed into service as a tent city for both naval and municipal government afterward.³⁴
- 3

Dobuita-dori どぶ板通り. Named for the iron plates the naval arsenal once supplied to cover a drainage ditch running down the street; long an America-facing shopping street and the birthplace of the souvenir sukajan jacket.⁷
- 4

Mikasa Park and the battleship Mikasa 三笠公園・記念艦みかさ. The 1902-built flagship of the Russo-Japanese War, designated a memorial ship in 1926, nearly lost to postwar neglect (a private lessee fitted an aquarium and a dance hall aboard) before a nationwide campaign restored it, rededicated on 27 May 1961.⁶¹⁶
- 5

Otaki-cho and Minato-cho 大滝町・港町. Now the city's central shopping streets, both built on land reclaimed

between 1869 and the 1880s from what a 1917 study describes as a shoreline of a few thatched huts.¹

The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2021



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2021 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2021*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed



1987–1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

Former water area 31%	Mountain and hill slopes 29%
Water 24%	Floodplain and coastal plain 8.3%
Foothill deposits 7.1%	Sandbars and dunes under 0.5%

What the main landforms mean

Former water area (31%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

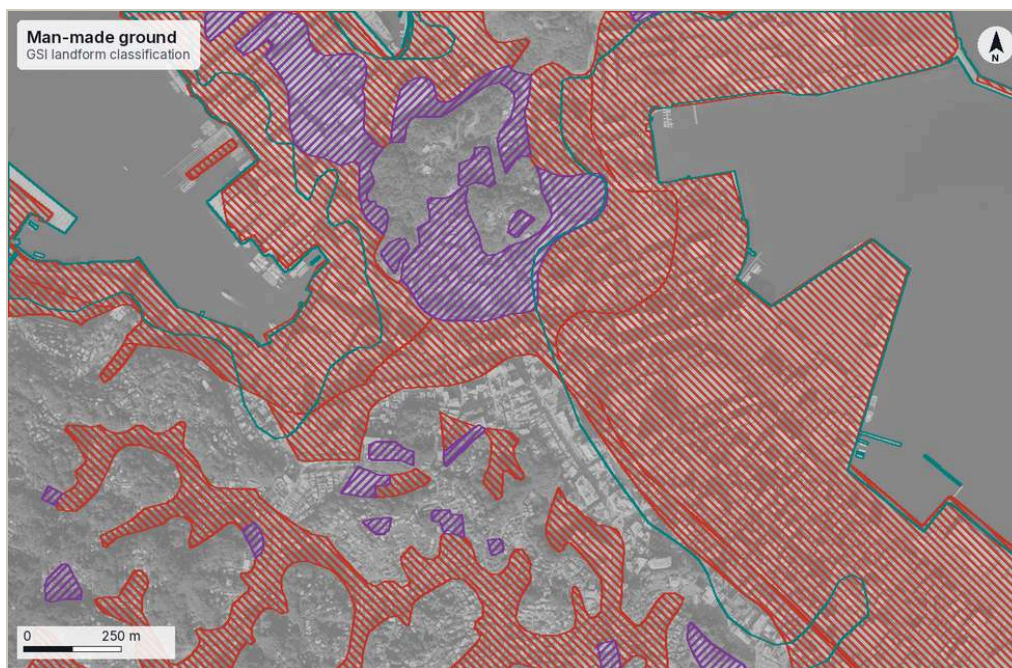
Mountain and hill slopes (29%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Floodplain and coastal plain (8.3%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Foothill deposits (7.1%). Gentler ground below mountains and scarps, built from debris brought down by slope failures and debris flows. Debris flows are possible in heavy rain; the ground is unstable and slopes may fail in earthquakes.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

-  Filled and reclaimed land 45%
-  Cut ground 6.1%

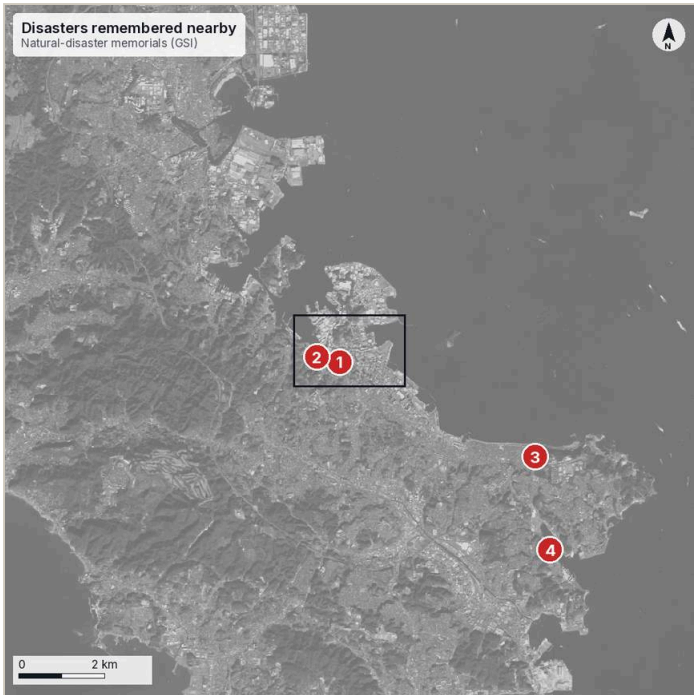
Meiji-era lowland

-  River, pond or sea 46%
-  Tidal flat or beach 2.9%
-  Rice paddy under 0.5%

Filled and reclaimed land (45%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Cut ground (6.1%). Ground made by cutting into slopes of mountains or terrace edges. Depending on the cut slope, heavy rain or earthquakes may bring it down; the ground itself is generally firm.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the refuge at Suwa Shrine after the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 大震災避難記念碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1925	0.3 km
2	Memorial to the Yokosuka victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 大震災遭難者供養塔	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · landslide or debris flow / earthquake	1929	0.8 km
3	Memorial to the 1923 earthquake dead who washed ashore at Mabori 大震災歿死者之霊	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake / other	1930	5.0 km
4	Memorial tower to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake in Uraga 関東大震災慰霊塔	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · landslide or debris flow / earthquake	1972	6.6 km

What the memorials record

- Memorial to the refuge at Suwa Shrine after the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake.** After the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, the number of people sheltering at Suwa Shrine reached 400 by 5 September, and some lived at the shrine for a while. The monument was put up by the evacuees themselves.
- Memorial to the Yokosuka victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake.** The Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 was a disaster without precedent. Yokosuka did not escape: there were scenes of devastation everywhere, and 517 people in the city died. The memorial was moved to this site in 1936; nearby are a stone listing the victims' names and a Jizo statue dedicated to them.
- Memorial to the 1923 earthquake dead who washed ashore at Mabori.** In the days and weeks after the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, around 10 bodies, thought to be victims from Tokyo and Yokohama, washed ashore on the Mabori coast of Yokosuka and were buried here. The memorial was erected in 1930, seven years after the disaster.
- Memorial tower to the victims of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake in Uraga.** The Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 caused slope collapses and fires in Uraga. In Nishi-Uraga, Mount Atago collapsed, burying 74 houses and about 100 people, and at Dokkuhara a slide buried 7 passers-by alive. The former town of Uraga alone lost 202 people. Rebuilt after the war, the tower honours victims of the earthquake and of shipwrecks.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

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Further reading

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- 横須賀百年史 (横須賀百年史編さん委員会編, 1965) — A centennial history of the city, covering the arsenal, the naval district and the postwar base transition. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/2995616> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
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- 旧・横須賀鎮守府庁舎&ドライドック：横須賀に眠る文化遺産 (長浜つぐお編, 1998) — A dedicated study of the surviving Naval District headquarters building and dry docks. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/14087286> (NDL premises only)

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **US Navy real-estate and requisition records for Yokosuka, 1945-1952** — US National Archives (NARA): SCAP/GHQ real estate division records; US Naval Forces Far East records. Search the NARA catalog for Yokosuka base requisition and occupation-period property files.
- **Detailed casualty and reconstruction figures for the 1923 earthquake in Yokosuka specifically** — Yokosuka City Museum (横須賀市自然・人文博物館) and the Kanagawa Prefectural Archives. Consult their disaster-history collections and any surviving ward-level damage maps.
- **Household-level records for the pre-1865 fishing hamlets absorbed into the Ironworks site** — Yokosuka City Museum and the National Archives of Japan (国立公文書館). Search for surviving Edo-period village registers (人別帳) for the Katsuriki and Oppama coastal hamlets.
- **US Navy personnel and family-housing history at Yokosuka through the Cold War** — US Naval History and Heritage Command and the Naval War College's archives. Contact the Command Historian's office directly, since history.navy.mil's own installation pages were unreachable this session.

Caveats

- Perry's 1853 landing itself took place at Kurihama, about 5 km south of this district's study center, not within the study area; it is described here only as regional context for the Ironworks that followed.
- Casualty numbers for the 1923 earthquake in Yokosuka specifically (as opposed to the wider Kanto region) are not stated as a single figure in the sources read this session; the dossier instead describes the qualitative pattern of destruction the 1932 record itself emphasises.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.